

MINNESOTA NATIVE PLANTS

Field Companion

Take this outside. Write on it.



A site-assessment checklist, a month-by-month maintenance calendar, and bloom charts for prairie, woodland and wetland — the parts of the book that work better on paper than on a screen.

arunbatchu.github.io/minnesota-native-plants

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01 — BEFORE YOU BUY ANYTHING

Assess the site

Fill this in before you choose a single plant. Almost every failed native planting is a plant put somewhere it was never adapted to.

THE BASICS

Date

Location / address

Bed name or area

SUN — COUNT IT, DON'T GUESS

Check the spot every two hours from 8am to 6pm on a clear midsummer day. March readings mislead: the canopy is not out yet.

- ☐ Full sun *6+ hours direct*
- ☐ Part sun / part shade *3–6 hours, or dappled*
- ☐ Full shade *under 3 hours*

Hours counted

MOISTURE — THE PERCOLATION TEST

Dig a hole 12 inches deep and across. Fill it, let it drain, fill again, and time the second drain.

- ☐ Under 1 hour *dry site*
- ☐ 1–4 hours *mesic — most Minnesota yards*
- ☐ Over 4 hours *wet site*

Drain time

SOIL — THE JAR TEST

A cup of soil in a quart jar of water with a teaspoon of dish soap. Shake, wait 48 hours. Sand settles first, then silt, then clay on top.

- ☐ Mostly sand *fast drainage, low fertility*
- ☐ Mostly clay *slow, holds nutrients*
- ☐ Roughly even — loam *widest plant choice*

USDA Web Soil Survey — map unit name

Marschner pre-settlement community

USDA hardiness zone

BEFORE YOU PLANT — THE LOCAL RULES

- ## SKETCH THE BED

02 — THE YEAR

Maintenance calendar

A native planting asks for less work than a lawn, but the work it does ask for is time-sensitive. Timing is what decides whether an hour spent helps or hurts.

January

- Order seed and plugs — good stock sells out by March
- Read; plan next season's bed

February

- Start 90-day stratification for lupine, shooting star
- Prune shrubs while dormant

March

- Start 60-day stratification for the bluestems, leadplant
- Frost-seed onto snow or frozen ground
- Cut last year's stems — late, so overwintering insects emerge

April

- Prescribed burn window, with training and permits
- First spring ephemerals — Bloodroot, Hepatica, Pasque Flower
- Queen bumble bees emerge and need flowers NOW

May

- Plant plugs and containers once frost risk passes
- Pull garlic mustard before seed pods mature
- Peak woodland bloom — visit a remnant to see it

June

- Water new plantings deeply: 1 inch a week, not daily sprinkles
- Cut wild parsnip roots below the crown — wear long sleeves
- Showy Lady's Slipper blooms in fens

July

- Spot-weed; do not let anything set seed
- Peak prairie bloom
- Leave the hose off unless it is a first-year planting

August

- Collect ripe seed — if you have to tug, it is not ready
- Take the 10% rule seriously; never from public land without a permit
- Cut-stump herbicide season opens for woody invasives

September

- Best month for cut-stump buckthorn treatment
- New bumble bee queens fattening — late bloom matters
- Divide and move perennials

October

- Leave the leaves; leave the stems standing
- Plant trees and shrubs
- Note the gaps — what had nothing blooming this year?

November

- Fall dormant seeding — let winter do the stratification
- Last call for cut-stump treatment

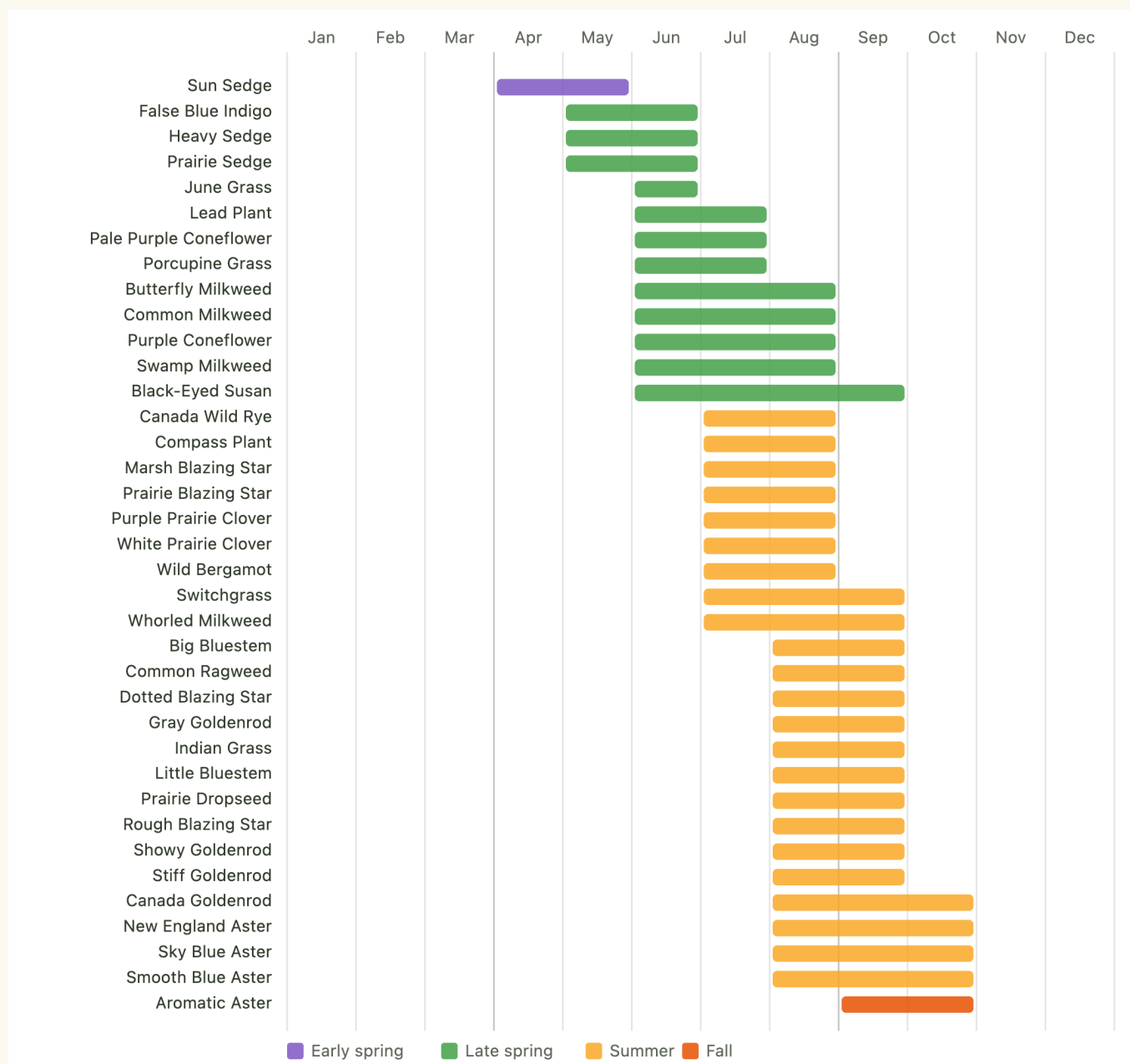
December

- Nothing. That is the correct answer.
- Winter tree ID: bark, buds, silhouette

03 — BLOOM SUCCESSION

Prairie

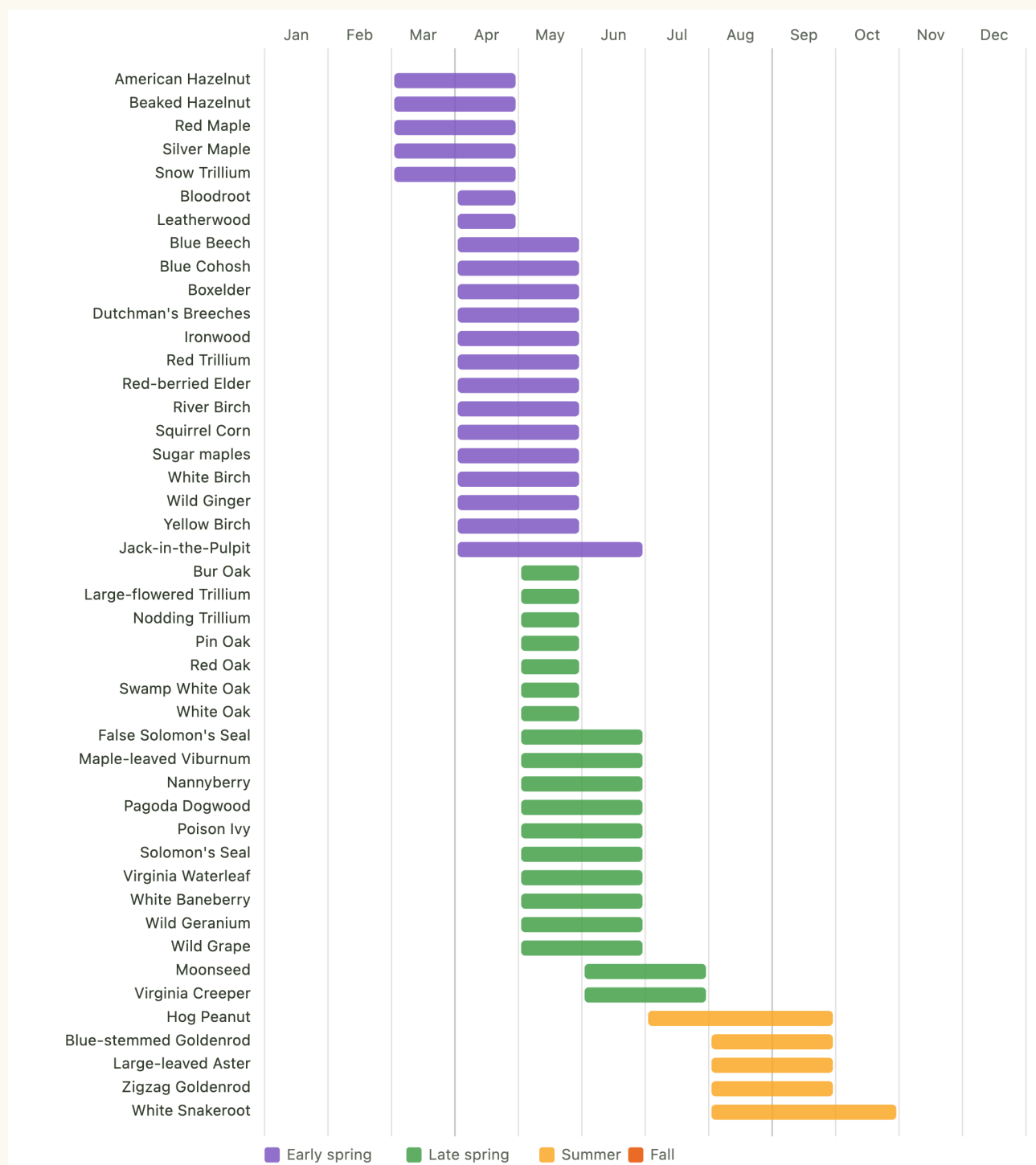
Every native prairie species in this book that flowers, by month. The heavier lines mark April and September — the two months a pollinator garden is most often missing.



03 — BLOOM SUCCESSION

Woodland

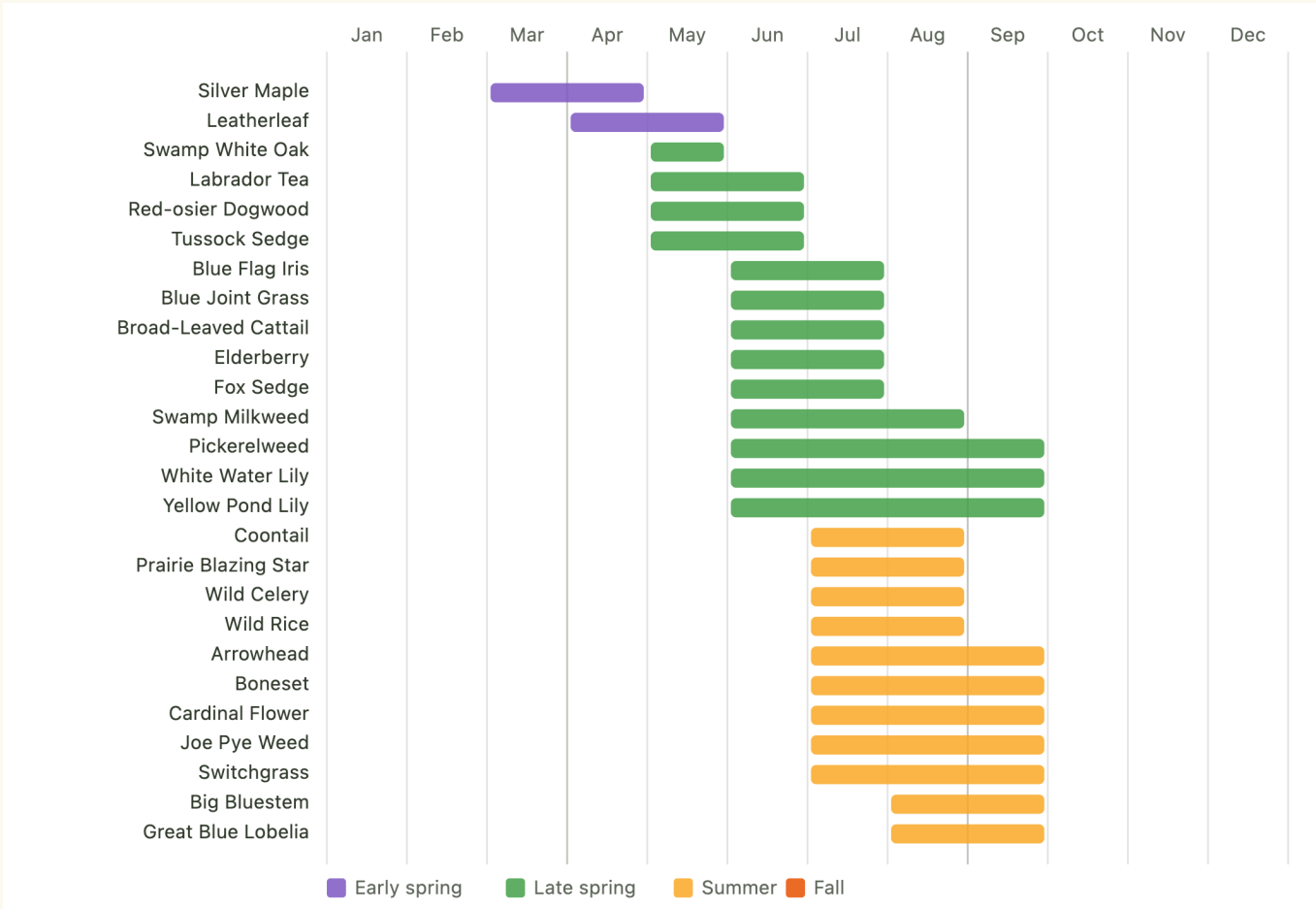
Most of the woodland year happens before June. That is the canopy closing, and it is why spring ephemerals move so fast.



03 — BLOOM SUCCESSION

Wetland and shoreline

Wetland and shoreline species by month.



Notes

What is blooming today, and what is not?

Notes

Species to look up when you get home.

The rest of the book lives online

17 chapters · 289 concepts · 22 interactive simulations

211 species cards · 340 quiz questions

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“Let's grow together.”

Bree — rusty-patched bumble bee (*Bombus affinis*),
Minnesota's state bee, federally endangered

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